When Awareness Fails in Practice

A case study in the gap between knowing and doing — and why cyber safety is a habit, not just a lesson.

PART 5: CYBER CRIME

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The Opportunity That Looked Real

Days after sending internship applications, Arjun received what appeared to be a direct response — a polished email from a well-known company offering a paid internship.

Professional Logo

Visually convincing branding that mimicked a real company

Structured Message

Formal tone and well-formatted content designed to appear legitimate

Urgency Trigger

"Limited slots" — act now or lose your opportunity

For Arjun, this felt like a breakthrough. Without thinking too deeply, **he clicked the link.**

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The Hidden Trap

What the Form Asked For

- Name and contact details
- Academic information
- **Email login credentials** — "for verification"

> Arjun had studied phishing in class. He hesitated — but the urgency and professional appearance pushed him to submit anyway.

Within hours: suspicious login alerts, password reset notifications, and unusual activity warnings confirmed the worst.

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Anatomy of the Phishing Email

On closer inspection, the red flags were clear — but only in hindsight.

Subject: Urgent: Internship Selection – Immediate Action Required

Dear Candidate, Congratulations! You have been shortlisted for our paid internship program. Due to limited positions, complete your verification *immediately* or your slot may be cancelled within **12 hours**.

— HR Team

Warning Signs Missed

- **Altered sender address** — subtly misspelled domain
- **Manufactured urgency** — 12-hour deadline to force panic
- **Sensitive data request** — no legitimate company asks for login credentials

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The Aftermath

Arjun acted quickly — changed passwords, enabled security settings — but the damage went beyond credentials.

Anxiety

Persistent worry about how his personal data might be misused

Broken Trust

Deep scepticism toward every online opportunity — legitimate or not

The Real Shock

Not the attack itself — but how easily he fell for it *despite knowing better*

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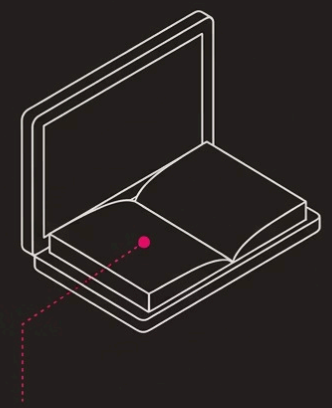
Knowledge vs. Behaviour: The Critical Gap



PHISHING DEFINITION.

DO NOT SHARE CREDENTIALS.

VERIFY SOURCES.

CLICKED WITHOUT VERIFYING.

TRUSTED APPEARANCES.

PRIORITISED URGENCY OVER CAUTION.

Why Awareness Isn't Enough

Cyber crimes succeed not because users are ignorant — but because in the moment, behaviour overrides knowledge.

- They act quickly without verifying
- They trust appearances over details
- They let opportunity override caution

Arjun's desire to secure an internship overpowered his judgement — a deeply human response that attackers deliberately exploit.

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Beyond the Individual: A Shared Responsibility

It is easy to blame the user. But digital platforms are engineered to encourage the very behaviours that attackers exploit.

Quick Responses Rewarded

Platforms are optimised for speed and instant action — leaving little room for deliberate thinking

Urgency by Design

Countdown timers, limited slots, and "act now" prompts are standard — and attackers mirror them precisely

Whose Responsibility?

Is cyber safety solely the user's burden, or must platform designers build safer, more friction-aware systems?

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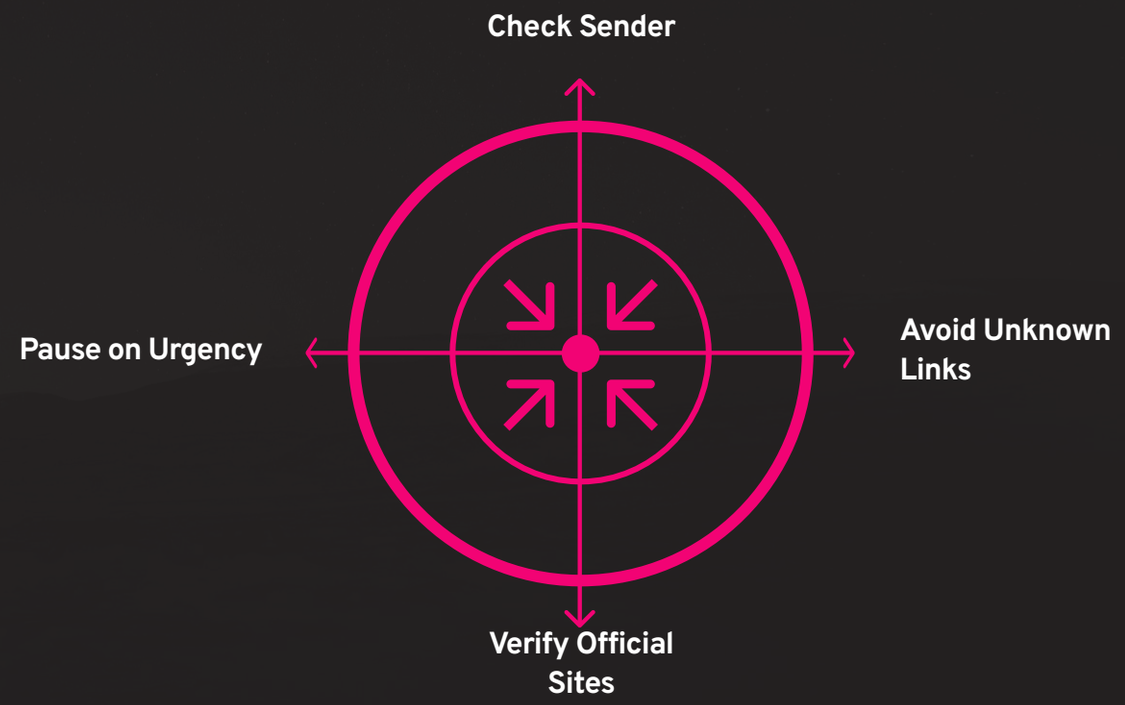
Prevention Is a Habit, Not a Lesson

After the incident, the most important change in Arjun was not what he *knew* — it was how he *behaved*.



These steps are simple — but each requires **conscious, deliberate effort**. Cyber safety is not a one-time lesson. It is a continuous habit of questioning and verifying.

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